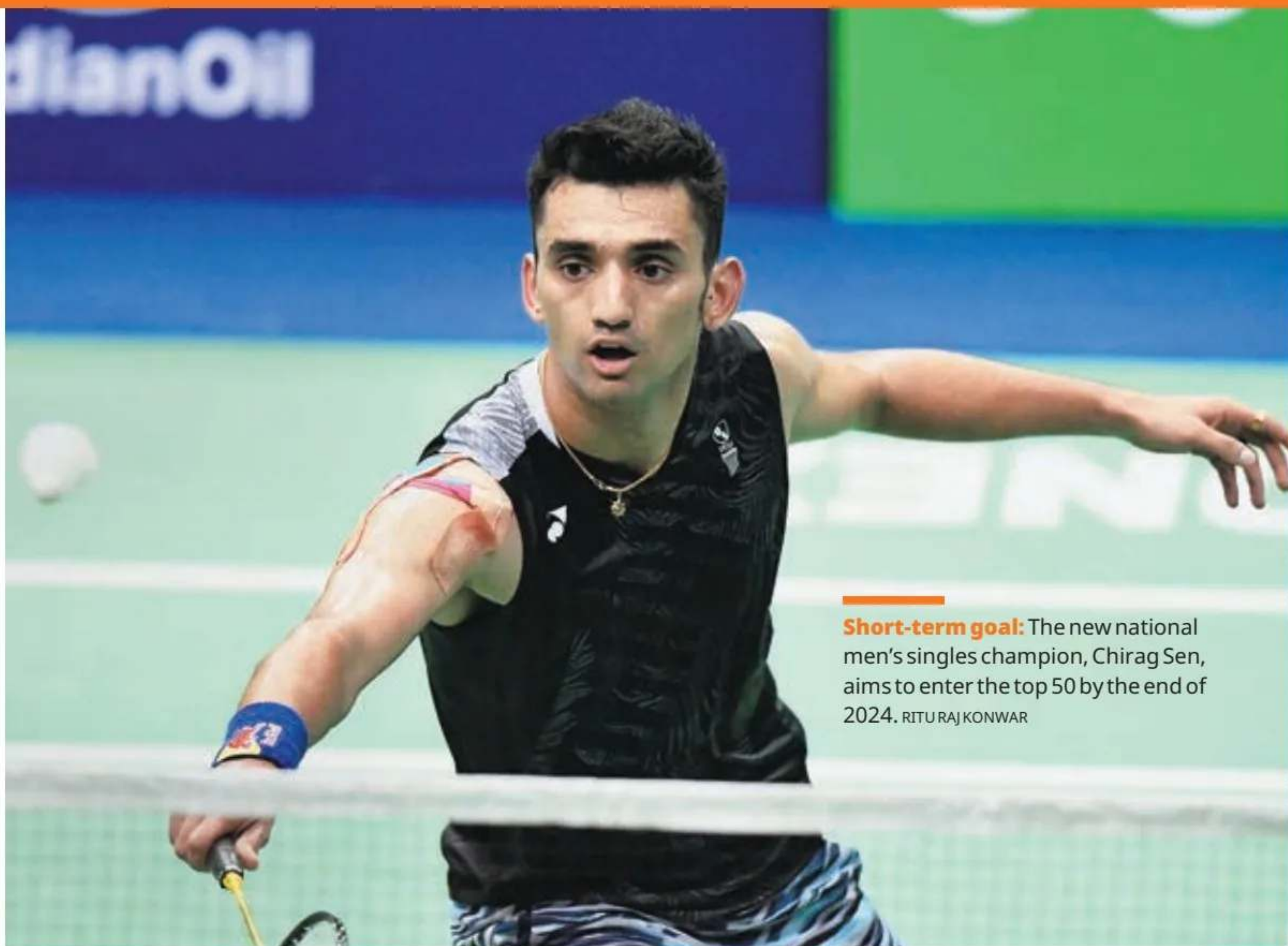




Short-term goal: The new national men's singles champion, Chirag Sen, aims to enter the top 50 by the end of 2024. RITU RAJ KONWAR

Memorial tournament over the past few years. He unequivocally states that Saina and Sindhu outshine Anmol and Tanvi by a significant margin. However, he believes that Anmol has the potential to make a substantial impact on the international stage in the senior category within the next 2-3 years.

Analysing Anmol's game, Sanjiv said: "Physically and mentally, she is strong and a good fighter. She has good defence and attack but needs to improve her speed. The best part is that she is very focused, unlike a few girls who relax after winning one or two national titles. Her drops and net play need to improve. She will only get better." Sanjiv, who has travelled extensively with Saina as a junior coach, noted that the latter consistently put in extra effort to enhance her weaker areas. "In her early days, Saina had a weak backhand. Every day, she worked hard on her overhead forehand shots."

In fact, when Saina and Sindhu were in their teens, they took part in more international tournaments in the senior section than Anmol and Tanvi have done so far.

Take, for example, Saina. She had won the Asian Satellite Tournament at the age of 15, beating a much-senior player in Aparna Popat in straight games. At 16 years old, Saina became the first Indian to win a four-star event, the Philippines Open in 2006.

Meanwhile, Sindhu, at 14, had played in the India Open, and in February 2010, when she had not yet turned 16, Sindhu rose from 255 to world No. 168, jumping 87 places, after reaching the final of the Iran Fajr International Challenge. In 2011, Sindhu cracked the top 100, being ranked world No. 98.

At the domestic level, Saina and Sindhu didn't take part in many senior national ranking events, including senior nationals, as they were busy competing in international

tournaments across the globe.

Trupti Murgunde, a former India player and current national selector, is pleased that the two talented young girls competed in the final. She emphasised that there is a group of talented girls capable of challenging senior players.

"Badminton is looking up. It's not just Anmol and Tanvi; there is Unnati Hooda, Tara Shah, Isharani Baruah, Rakshitha Sree, and other young girls performing well at the national level. It is good that there is competition among them," she said.

"I am not belittling their [Anmol and Tanvi] achievements. What they have done is great. It's good that youngsters are doing well at the senior level. Let's give them some more time and not jump to conclusions based on one tournament. In the juniors, the depth is good, and there is healthy competition," remarked Trupti.

The 41-year-old, a former National Women's Singles Champion, said